



passion for teaching die. He is a visiting faculty at IIT Roorkee and other academic institutions. But Satya refuses to take a permanent post. He says, “I felt I will not be suitable for regular teaching. I would rather guide them toward the right kind of technology and the right kind of design expertise rather than teaching a semester-long course.”

Finding love at IIT, keeping up with hobbies and retirement plans

Satya might be a trailblazer in the semiconductor industry, but he is a romantic at heart. He has been married to his wife for 32 years now. Although it was a love marriage, it has had its twists and turns, just like every aspect of Satya’s life. Satya and his wife were working on the same project at IIT Delhi, and while there, they developed a close bond as friends. He recalls, “We were very close. It reached a point where she and a couple of my friends were trying to find a girl for me!”

They ended up in the U.S. together when both Satya and Madhurima went on to pursue their PhDs. His wife was a strong support system for him there, and it was during a meeting with their advisor that they realised that what they had could not be dismissed as just friendship. He says, “Our advisor told us: You guys must be mad. You are so close, why don’t you try being in a relationship.”

These words resonated with the couple, who soon decided to tie the knot. But since his wife was a Bengali, Satya had some convincing to do at home. “They eventually agreed and we got married in a Hindu-Bengali wedding in 1990, while I was two years into my PhD,” Satya recalls.

His wife is also in the

Satya’s Learnings from being A Serial Entrepreneur

- Don’t build anything that you can’t sell. Coming from the technology field, we have this notion that technology is everything in a startup, which is not true most of the time. No matter how good your technology is, if you can’t sell it then it is of no use.
- Not every CTO makes a good CEO. You might think that it is your idea so you should be the CEO, but you may be more suitable as a CTO since the CEO is also your Chief Sales Officer and Chief Spokesperson.
- People buy products, not just technology. Focus on product engineering and product marketing. If your product has a global look and feel, half your selling is done anyway.

chip design industry but she quit her job in Qualcomm a few years ago to teach underprivileged children at an NGO based in Bengaluru. The couple have a son, Abhishek, who is on his way to becoming a faculty member at the University of Washington at Seattle.

Despite handling multiple fronts of multiple organisations, Satya finds time to keep up with his varied interests and hobbies. His love for carpentry still prevails. “When I was in the USA, I used to watch a TV show, The New Yankee Workshop, on carpentry, after which I bought a few carpentry tools and started building furniture myself. When we shifted to India, half of the luggage consisted of woodworking tools!”

Satya is also an avid painter. While he was interested in charcoal sketching initially, digital painting has been his recent hobby. If all this

was not enough, Satya also enjoys music—although he says he does not have the voice to sing—and knows how to play the keyboard.

For a person handling so many fronts successfully while also keeping up with his interest, we had to ask—when does Satya plan to rest? “I have no retirement plans,” he concludes. “If I do not work, what will I do? I can pursue my hobbies, but if I do not do something professionally, I don’t think I’m going to enjoy it. I want to keep working till my mind and body works.”

Showing a glimpse of his impeccable commitment to his craft, Satya refuses to work for money anymore. “I only want to work on a pro-bono basis, I opt-out if someone offers me money.”

Having spent so many years building multiple startups and working tirelessly on a common mission, what is something Satya would like to say to his younger self?

“I’d say, be committed to whatever you’re doing. If you are committed to whatever you are doing, it will make everything better. Whenever opportunities come, take judicious risks, because risks are going to be there whenever you want to do something special. Also, don’t make decisions based on work-life balance—your decision should be based on your commitment to your profession and then focus on having a balanced lifestyle.” **EFY**



Man, woman and child—A painting by Dr Satya Gupta